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Bill Crow

Bill Crow has enjoyed a multi-faceted music career. His successful performing career as a bassist allowed him into the inner circle of great jazz musicians where he became fascinated with the stories they had to share. His recent book Jazz Anecdotes *gathers these marvelous tales for the public and has established Bill as a major jazz writer. His articles and reviews have appeared in* Down Beat *and* Jazz Review. *Bill also finds time to be an officer for the American Federation of Musicians Local 802, where he represents the interests of performing musicians in a rapidly changing industry.*

Bill was interviewed in New York City on October 18, 1995 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and it's our great pleasure to have with us Bill Crow, who has multiple careers in music, as a bass player and a writer and working with the musicians, which is kind of first for us to be talking in that area, so it will be interesting to hear about how that work is going. Welcome, and I'd love to talk about some of your writing. First of all, can I guess that you were a player before you were a writer?

BC: Yeah, well, I've always been interested in writing. I was a big reader when I was a kid, I learned to read before I started grade school. My mother had a little primer and she taught me at home. She also taught me to sing and I guess I inherited my musical ears from her. She was a musician. But I can remember standing by her ironing board singing songs with her before I could see up over the ironing board, so I know I was pretty young. And she tells me that when I still used to take naps in the afternoon in my little crib in the bedroom, when she would be teaching a singing student, she would sing the exercise she wanted them to sing, and then the student would sing it, and then they'd have to pause for me to sing it. But she got me started reading and I was omnivorous reader. I think while I was still in grade school in this small town outside Seattle, Washington — Kirkland, Washington is where I grew up, there was a small library operated by the ladies' club. And the building is still there by the way. I was out there this summer and saw that it's now a national landmark. But they had accumulated a nice little library of books for a small town, in the 20s and 30s. And before I was out of the fifth grade I'd read everything in that library. In fact when I got into Greek mythology I had to get a note from my mother — they wanted to make sure I wasn't pressing flowers in these big books or something. But I read everything in the library it was fantastic. I'd take three or four books home a week and plow through them, you know? And so by the time I was in school I was always interested in English and composition and the teachers of those

things saw me as a prized student. So they fed me stuff. I think it was a sixth grade teacher that gave me copies of the *New Yorker*, which I'd never seen before. And I fell in love with James Thurber and E.B. White and Alexander Wolcott, and became quite a sophisticate for the small town that we were in. Some of the terms I didn't understand at all, I had to go find out what they were talking about, but that was my beginning of my appreciation of really good writing. And I think E.B. White became my hero because he was such a master of the simple declarative sentence. He said what it was that he had on his mind without any question about what it was. He had a good sense of humor. And he was interested in things. Joseph Mitchell was another of my great heroes. He wrote articles about New York for the *New Yorker* and his stuff is now collected in a wonderful book. But unfortunately he hasn't written anything. He's still around but he hasn't written anything for quite a while.

MR: Did this influence your eventually coming to New York?

BC: Well when I came to New York it was on the suggestion — you know I'd been in the Army for a while and I had been out here on a visit once just out of high school. But the idea of ever leaving Kirkland, Washington was not a strong possibility. You know we were depression kids and just the idea that anybody would go anywhere else in the first place you didn't think you could afford it. You might go to Seattle, but that's about the limit of our scope at that time. And the idea that anybody would become a professional musician was not within our realm of possibility because we didn't know any. We knew some music teachers. And we knew lots of amateur musicians. Everybody was a musician in those days.

MR: It was a social —

BC: Well you know in the 20s and 30s, everybody at least sang. I remember singing almost everywhere I went. If we went to church we sang. If we went to an American Legion meeting we sang. If we went to somebody's house within a half hour after dinner we would be around the piano singing the songs everybody knew. You know, Stephen Foster songs, World War I songs, stuff like that. And everybody sang. There was no such thing as somebody without a voice. There were people that it was understood they didn't have strong voices, or that they sang a little sharp or that the quality of their voice was a little raspy, but that didn't make pariahs of them. Everybody was expected to try and the strong singers carried it. So we've come to an age now where we lean on professionals tremendously. We've become watchers instead of participants. And I think it's kind of unfortunate because there was a quality of sharing that music experience in the community singing and the school bands and that whole thing that was I think the Swing Era, that kind of playing that went on in big bands, was a direct outgrowth of that. It was the whole thrill of playing well together in a big band is becoming really skilled at getting

together like that. Everybody appreciated barber shop harmony and that sort of thing, and when you got into a big band and could play riffs together or could read dumb stock together and really make it into some music, that was a thrilling achievement.

MR: Do you think that change is partly because of the entertainment that's available every place you go?

BC: Sure. I mean I saw it happen when I was a kid. My mother used to take the ferry to Seattle and ride the streetcar up over the hill down to where the radio station was, and on the local Seattle radio station she would sing songs or play the organ and make $5 for the program, something like that. But I mean that was a big income in those days, supplementing what my dad was making. Everybody was out of work and he was scuffling, and $5 really made the difference between whether we had meat on the table or not sometimes. And when the Seattle radio station joined the network and all the programs started coming out of Chicago, those jobs vanished. She continued to play on the radio but it was for free on church programs. So then her extra income came from playing at funerals and weddings and things like that. She had also participated in a previous automation where when she was a young girl she played the piano for the silent movies down in Arizona where she lived. And of course when sound came in, that wiped out all those little piano players and also all the pit orchestras in the big cities that used to play for the movies.

MR: So when did the bass come into the picture here?

BC: Well it's funny. I was a brass player all the time I was a kid. I wanted to be, my mother started me on piano and I hit a wall about the John M. Williams second book I think. I couldn't get both hands to pay attention to what they were doing. But in the fourth grade a wonderful man came to our school, Al Benest was his name, and took over the whole music system from high school to grade school. He saw that he didn't have much to work with because the previous person had been kind of perfunctory and his whole band was graduating that year and nothing was coming up. So I was in the fourth grade, he came down and passed out sheets of paper and said who wants to play what instrument, I'll talk to your folks. So I knew what a trumpet was and I thought that was probably a nice instrument. So I wrote down trumpet. And he came and talked to my mom and dad and they agreed that they would get me one. Now they were poor as church mice at the time but there was a trumpet in the Sears Roebuck catalogue for $9.95 with case, and that's what they got me. Now I had to wait a week to get it, the shipping of it was kind of slow. So I went to the band rehearsals every morning with the other kids and I'd sit there and watch them fingering, and then when I finally got my horn I was playing more watching their fingerings. But I had great ears, and I would learn the music within a day or two, if we played it twice I had it. So I didn't get to be a good reader right away, I was a good

listener and a kind of a sad reader. But by the time I was in the sixth grade I was disappointed that I couldn't play the melodies. I couldn't get enough lip to play the high notes so they wouldn't put me on first. And I complained to the teacher, and he said, "Well let me see your teeth," you know, and he says, "you may never really get a good trumpet embouchure with those front teeth." I got a pair of front teeth that stick out a little bit. But he said, "The school owns a baritone horn. It has a bigger mouthpiece, the music reads just the same as the trumpet, and it has all the good parts" he tells me. Which is true — when they transcribe from the orchestra to the concert band, they take all the cello parts and give them to the baritone horn. And the clincher was he told me he had played that instrument at one time. I knew he was a trombone player. So and I was crazy about him so I said, "All right, I'll try it." By this time I think my dad had gotten me a $40 trumpet that was made out of silver instead of brass, hoping that that would help me out. It didn't, so when I got this school horn, he took the horn back and got his money back and I was out of the trumpet business. Well it turned out that the baritone horn was a beautiful instrument. I loved it and I learned to play it well, and by the time I was in high school I got an after school job and bought a horn of my own that was really a good sounding instrument. And I would win solo contests and you know, I was considered an exceptional baritone horn player. When I got into college, I went to the University of Washington for a little while before I went in the army. And they had all of the baritone chairs were full. I couldn't be a baritone horn player there. I was crushed. But they offered me an E flat tuba, which I tried, sousaphone—

MR: Getting lower and lower as you go on.

BC: So I played that a little bit, didn't really like it, and didn't have an opportunity to get into any music on it, because the stuff we were playing, the parts weren't very interesting. And by this time I'd become interested in jazz. And in high school this same teacher had formed a little swing band, played stocks and was trying to teach us how that idiom went. So I'd bring my baritone horn to rehearsal and say where are the baritone horn parts? And again I was crushed to discover that they didn't write for that instrument. So I fooled around the last year of high school. I tried saxophone for a while because my older brother had an old Buescher alto that he'd left behind when he went in the Navy, and I never got a good sound on that. And when some better — I guess I started that in my junior year. And when some better saxophones came into the band I was aced out immediately. But the drummer had graduated so I ran over to the service station where he worked and said, "Show me that thing you play on the hi-hat," and, "how do you do this" and "what are the basic things you need to know about drumming?" I could hear what the drummers had been doing, and I did that well enough. I was a fairly decent drummer because I could keep time. But when it got into really being a jazz drummer later on, I

had trouble with I wanted everything to be symmetrical, and jazz players have to be able to keep the time going with one hand while they do other things with their other hands. And I always wanted to do things that were symmetrical, and I couldn't get the asymmetrical things to work right for me. So I eventually gave up drums just by default, but I played them, oh, through high school and in college a little bit. And when I got in the Army, all the drummers in the band I finally got into as a baritone player, were street drummers. So when we would have club dates and service club jobs for dancing, I would be the trap drummer. I met a cornet player from Brookline, Massachusetts in the Army who was a real moldy fig in those days. He loved everything from Louis Armstrong up to about Mugsy Spanier.

MR: A moldy fig. I haven't heard that term in a while.

BC: That was an old term. Yeah. The figs and the boppers in those days. But at that time I had never heard of bebop. I had a pretty good jazz collection. I collected everything from Duke Ellington, of course, the big bands that were popular in those days. I collected jazz just because it was pop music. I was collecting Benny Goodman, Harry James, Tommy Dorsey, Glenn Miller, all that stuff. But by some wonderful fluke, this little electric store that sold stoves and refrigerators in Kirkland, Washington, had a little corner in the back with a stack of 78s and the distributor for some reason was sending them these little tiny labels from New York like Moe Ash and Signature and Guild, and labels like that. So I all of a sudden started hearing musicians like Don Byas and Eddie Miller and Mary Lou Williams and Bill Coleman and small group jazz that I'd never heard much before except on Benny Goodman records. So I was very interested in that. And then I found out about Edmond Hall and some of the more traditional players, just through these records that were there. They were all mixed together. I had no idea about styles or periods, they were just all good jazz to me. So and somehow I missed Count Basie completely. He wasn't among those records.

MR: Wasn't in the pile, that's all.

BC: So when I got into the Army, first I came under the influence of this moldy fig who taught me that whole repertoire which has stood me in great good stead as a professional musician, because I know all of the Armstrong stuff, the traditional Chicago jazz tunes. And then another guy came in from Massillon, Ohio, who was a Bebopper. And we said, "What's Bebop, we don't know—" And he said, "Well there's a station out of Chicago late at night we can probably get." We were stationed in Baltimore at that time. So we would stay up at night and get the Dave Garroway show. And Dave was the disc jockey at that time in Chicago who liked Sarah Vaughan and George Treadwell's arrangements, and Charlie Parker, and the more melodic stuff. He didn't really go into the outside music. But that was my first taste. And it sounded wonderful to me. I'd been listening to

classical composers that used that kind of harmony anyway, Ravel and Debussy and Mahler. So it just seemed like a natural addition to what I was already listening to but my moldy fig friend was outraged. He said, "You can't like that music!" I said, "How do I stop myself?" So I didn't see why I couldn't play both kinds, and I have to this day.

MR: You said something, almost in passing that I wonder if you could elaborate on. You said jazz was pop music. And we sometimes forget—

BC: There was a Seaberg jukebox in the soda fountain in Kirkland, Washington where I used to go get my after school sodas, that had twelve selections on it. Twelve 78 records. And out of those twelve, I would say six were hip records. There would be one or two Duke Ellington tunes, there would always be a Benny Goodman tune, a Glenn Miller, and couple of Tommy Dorseys. Then you would also have Kay Kyser, and some of the novelty bands and some of the sweet bands — Sammy Kaye and like that. But I go into a jukebox place now where they've got four hundred to a thousand choices, and there's not one thing I want to listen to. It's just unreal. But the wheel turns. It just happened that what was being made popular by the new media at that time — records and radio — included jazz. They needed product. They needed anything to put on the air at that time.

MR: The radio was a really big part of spreading this music.

BC: Oh, yeah. And radio, I mean there weren't the number of people producing stuff for radio. And advertisers didn't understand how valuable radio was. Musicians didn't understand how valuable the advertising of having a record was. There were early musicians that wouldn't record because they were afraid that people would steal their music. So the first people who recorded became insanely popular.

MR: Wasn't that the story with Freddie Keppard? And he passed up the chance to be the first Dixieland group?

BC: Yeah. Wouldn't record. But as soon as people began to realize that then to get a record was important if you wanted to be a popular band, and to get a job in a club that had a radio wire at night was important. That was one of the big things that built the bands at the Hickory House. I used to work there with Marian McPartland. But in the years before that, when they were first starting out, at night, they didn't have a whole lot of sponsored programs. So all the radio stations would put telephone wires into the local nightclubs and ballrooms, and they would send a guy out to do a half hour remote. Birdland became very nationally known just because they had a radio wire. And every Tuesday night when the new act would come in, the first set was broadcast on the radio. Everybody turned on, say, "Hey that sounds good," they'd go down and hear the music. But not only that, people out of town would get these programs. And when they came to New York they had an address that they knew and a place to go, you know. It made all the difference in the world. It was wonderful.

MR: So when did you arrive in New York, officially?

BC: Well when I got out of the Army, I was here for like a three day pass in the Army and a quick visit once before out of high school. But I went back to Seattle and re-entered the University of Washington. And this time instead of living at home I moved in to be closer to the campus. A friend had a houseboat on Lake Union that was full of musicians, and I lived there. And I met a drummer there who had been out on the road with bands and came from Olympia, Washington, but he'd been living in New York and he knew the scene. And we became friends. I played with a band he put together there in Seattle for a couple of months. But then he was going with a girl piano player that had come through and gotten stranded in Seattle, an all-girl band. And first he got a job so that she could work with him there and that was when I was playing with him. But then she decided that she was ready to go home so he decided he was ready to go to New York to be with her. And he was talking to me one night and he says, "You know, man, if you want to be a musician, you've got to go to where the music is, you know, it's the only way you're going to learn it and it's the only way you're going to get into it. So why don't you come to New York with me?" It sounded reasonable to me, so I think we had our bus tickets and about fifty bucks, something like that. We got on the Greyhound and came out here. And that was January of 1950. And I guess, well I ran out of my fifty dollars pretty fast, and I had picked up the printing trade a little bit while I was in high school. I hadn't done it since I'd been in the Army, but I remembered enough of it to go downtown and apply for a job feeding a hand press. And I think the first agency I went to they asked me enough questions that reminded me enough of what the terms were that I was able to go to the second one and sound like a professional, and they got me a job up in the Bronx at a horrible little print shop where people screamed at each other constantly. I kind of liked that work but I was used to people being nice. I had learned it in the small town, where the printers were all genial and humorous, and these people were just like — Arghhhh! But they were paying me thirty dollars a week, and out of that thirty dollars I was splitting a room with a drummer on 83rd street or 86th street, in the 80s there someplace, taking a weekly lesson with Lennie Tristano out in Flushing, on the valve trombone, I had switched to valve trombone to get more into jazz. And I was seeing a therapist. I was interested in the writings of Wilhelm Reich in those days. And the thing to do was to go get yourself straightened out by a well known therapist. So actually the therapist I found was quite sympathetic and he got me, I didn't even know why I was there. I couldn't give him a particularly good reason. But he got me into a different place. I had always been a very nice boy who tried to please everyone, and felt very anxious because some people I couldn't seem to please. And he got me to thinking about what did I like and what did I want to do with myself, and who was I, and all of that. These are not questions that I'd

ever addressed. So I got to a point with him where I couldn't stand my day job, and decided that I couldn't go there anymore. It was just emotionally too shattering to go into that atmosphere every day. So without my day job, then I fell behind on my payments to my therapist, and he suggested that I go out and get another job and live my life and maybe I could afford to talk to a therapist sometime in the future. So I did. I scuffled around New York. And actually I was very lucky to have fallen in with Dave Lambert and his wife and four year old daughter. They were living down in the lower East Side on a part of Monroe Street that's no longer there now, they've built a project across that section of the block. But they had a twenty dollar a month apartment and they were happy as clams, and they had no income. And so they taught me how to survive. You know it doesn't make you a bad person to be poor, and that it's possible to still live and be productive and live kind of hand to mouth. It wasn't that he had no income, it's just that he didn't know where the next dollar was going to come from. But he was a willing worker and he had a wonderful attitude toward giving people value for service, and if you couldn't, if you had to prevail on somebody to give you a handout, at least you could entertain them. So he was always very welcome at parties. He knew a few songwriters who were willing to give us a meal, that kind of thing. So I really got my New York education from Davey. He showed me how to scuffle and he showed me who the interesting people were, whether they were making any money or not, he knew who the artists were and who the interesting characters were around town. And that was a wonderful education for me. And also through him, let's see now, well I had already known this guy Buzzy that I came out here with. And they all introduced me to people like Neal Hefti and Gene Roland and Moondog, and Larry Rivers was a tenor player there then instead of a painter, and a whole world of jam sessions: Zoot Simms and Brew Moore and people that were just around playing wherever there was a loft or a rehearsal studio or someplace like that to play. And the first summer that I was here, Buzzy got a job with Gene Roland up in Tupper Lake, New York, you may know where that is, a place called the Altamont Hotel, it burned down later, but it was a nice old hotel and it was far enough out of the real borsht belt type of entertainment that they didn't have a set agenda for what an entertaining band should be. So Gene had talked them into a quartet. He went up there with drums, tenor, piano, and maybe a saxophone player, I'm not sure. But anyway Buzzy was his drummer. And the first night that they were on the job they were going to go up for the summer in 1950. The first night on the job Gene has a big fight with the boss's wife and stalks out, abandons the band. So Buzzy goes to the boss and says "look there's no reason why you should be stuck without a band, let me go to New York and get you some guys" because he didn't particularly like the other guys that Gene had hired. So he became the band leader. He came back and he hired Freddy

Greenwell, wonderful tenor player who had been living in Seattle for a long time; and a trumpet player named Marty Bell, who is still around in Florida someplace; and a piano player named John Vincent Brooks, who had been the arranger for Randy Brooks' band when Buzzy was on that band. Buzzy Bridgeford was his name. And he couldn't hire a bass player, the boss wouldn't go for another rhythm instrument. So he goes back up with this quartet, and he tells me when he leaves, he said "look, we're going to be up there all summer, if things get to be a drag in New York, why don't you hitchhike up and I'll put you up for a weekend and you'll have a nice vacation in the mountains." So I did that. Actually they had decided to hire a singer and an emcee to go up, and the two of us hitchhiked up there together on the Fourth of July weekend. I think it took us something like 25 hours to hitchhike, because nobody was picking up any two guys with instrument cases. So I got up there and sat in with the band, and faked some three part harmony with the tenor and the trumpet, and Buzzy goes over to the boss and says, "how do you like the way the band sounds? Nice and full, right?" Boss says "yeah I guess so." He says "you know this trombone player is very much in demand in New York but his doctor found a spot on his lung and he's going to have to stay up in the mountains for a while. I think maybe if you made him an offer you could get him." So the boss says "offer him fifteen bucks a week and room and board, see how that grabs him." It was a Manna from heaven. So I stayed there for the summer. And of course the third day I was on the job I come to work and there's a string bass on the stand. I said to Buzzy "did you hire a bass player?" He says "no" he says, "I can't stand playing without a bass so I rented this from a kid that owns one" and I don't know he gave him ten bucks for the summer or something like that you know. And he says "whoever isn't playing has to play the bass. I can't stand this." So they gaslighted me into being the bass player. Freddy wasn't interested in it, and I didn't mind it. It was kind of an interesting problem, you know. And they would take me upstairs and play me records of Walter Page — "Listen to what he's doing with Count Basie." Or Ray Brown, "Listen to what he's doing, listen, try to get that long sound." They had nothing to tell me about how to do any of this. It was just this is what we want to hear. Which was wonderful. I figured out my own fingering system and the piano player would get together with me everyday and teach me chords, and they would tape record the thing or wire record, I can't remember what kind of recorder the tenor player had, and they would play me little sections where I actually sounded good, and says, "Now that's what you—" So by the end of the summer I had found my way around on the thing and was able to play well enough to get by. And when I came back to New York I would go down to Charlie's Tavern looking for work and nobody wanted a valve trombone player, but occasionally somebody needed a bass player for Saturday night. Of course I didn't have a bass, but in those days I could run over to Sixth Avenue to Noel

Wolfe's String Shop and rent an old beat up bass that he had there. He would charge $5 for the weekend. And then I'd run down the street to Jack Silver's Tuxedo Shop and rent a jacket or a tux for another $5. And the job paid $15, on which the profit of $5 I could live for a week you know?

MR: Oh, Lord, that's great.

BC: It was a lot of eating at Horn and Hardart's. My room on 8th Avenue and 52nd Street was the first room I had, was $8 a week. And then when I found this drummer that was going to the Art Student's League, he found a spot up in the 80s that was $12 a week that we could split, you know.

MR: Well that's great. That's some major scuffling. When did you first start to do some writing?

BC: Well I had done writing just as a writing exercise all through school and college. One of the best college courses I ever took was a creative writing class where the woman gave us a lot of freedom, just showed us how to research and gave us a lot of freedom to write whatever we wanted. And somewhere I think after I started working for Stan Getz in about 1953, in there someplace, I had been through let's see, Teddy Charles I think was my first really jazz group. I worked with his trio and he taught me all the Bebop changes. And then Jimmy Raney, I came to work with him with Stan Getz wasn't working, he had been Stan's regular guitar player, and he took me on to Stan's band. And right around that time I met a couple of writers for *Down Beat*, Nat Hentoff I think was still living in Boston and had started writing for *Down Beat*. And just in chatting with these guys, they realized that I could express myself clearly when talking about music so they would come and ask me what I thought about different things. And eventually somebody asked me to do an article for *Down Beat* and I did that. And then years later when I think I was with Gerry Mulligan by then, Nat Hentoff and Martin Williams and a guy named Hsio Wen Shih, a Chinese man, started a magazine called the *Jazz Review*. It only lasted a couple of years. But their idea was to get musicians to write reviews. They thought they could get it closer to the horse's mouth. So they asked me and I think the people who agreed to write reviews were me, Cannonball Adderley, Bill Evans, gee I can't remember now. They had quite a stable of guys. They didn't pay you anything, they'd just give you the records and you would, that way our opinions remained "pure" I believe. But it was a good exercise. It made me really think what I thought about the music and try to say it clearly. I finally decided I didn't like writing music reviews because there was really a conflict of interest as a professional, you know that even if you used the most careful terms, you could be wounding a colleague's career, and I just got uncomfortable with it just about the time that the magazine died. I still do occasional book reviews for the union paper whenever they need somebody to do that once in a while. And I don't really consider myself a

professional writer and I'm not going to get in anybody's way by saying what I think about some things that I review there, but I don't really like reviewing music anymore.

MR: What, this was what year about?

BC: The *Jazz Review*? That was in the 50s, you know I've lost track of that completely. Late 50s, early 60s I would imagine.

MR: Is this about the time you mentioned you saw the Basie band come in to Birdland?

BC: Oh that was earlier. You know I became a denizen of Birdland as soon as I got to town. That was the one place that was available to me. That's why I rented that first room a block away on 8th Avenue. I'd go down there every night because I didn't have much of anyplace else to go. And I think the admission was less than a dollar then. And you could go down and sit in the bleachers and you didn't have to spend another nickel, and listen to Charlie Parker, you know? He was there with his own band for the first two or three weeks I was in town and then it was, and the house band was just as strong, it was all the guys that had worked with Bird — Hank Jones and Miles, I think Red Rodney was with Bird at that time but Miles was in the house band. J.J. Johnson was in the house band, Max Roach was in the house band. It was wonderful. And they — everybody would come by and play or come by and listen. I got to know what all the musicians looked like anyway. Lester Young would be in the house and Art Tatum came in and sat in one night, and that was the first place I saw Jo Jones live. So it was someplace in the early 50s there, that Birdland decided to remodel and redecorate. They added some acoustical tiles and stuff like that so that they could put Basie in there once in a while. This was a new idea to put a big band in a small club like that. I guess it had been done on the street before, but not while I was around. So Basie had been working with a small group, just for economic reasons, and I think this was right at the time that he put the new band together. His managers talked Birdland, well I guess his managers were connected with Birdland in some kind of way. It was a whole small-time mob relationship there. I believe Morris Levy was known as a wise guy and his brother, who later got knifed in Birdland, was just a little like a street punk that everybody knew was mob connected. But they put the Basie band in there. I think the deal was that since it was in town and they would guarantee them something like three or four appearances a year, that they didn't have to pay them their road salary. You know they would get the band at a bargain rate that way. So here comes the band. I was working with Terry Gibbs' quartet about that time, so that must have been '52 or early 53, because I went with Thornhill—no, no, I was with Thornhill in '53 and then I went with Terry. So it was '53. We had this two week booking opposite the Basie band. I think it was the first time that they'd had Count in there. And let's see Eddie Jones was the bass player, Gus Johnson was the drummer, Renauld Jones was playing lead trumpet, Joe Newman was with them, Frank Wess and Frank Foster, they

featured them on a number called "Two Franks." And Benny Powell was in the trombone section, Wendell Cully I think. Thad Jones hadn't come on the band yet I think. I can't remember now whether Joe Wilder was there or not. But I know there was a lot of changing around that went on from time to time in the band.

MR: Marshall Royal? Was he on?

BC: Marshall was the section leader, right. And Charlie Fowlkes was the baritone player. And Freddie Green of course was in. And I can't remember now whether it was that time or the next time that he came in that Joe Williams was with him. It seems to me that he didn't have a singer that first time when we were opposite them. Because it seems to me I seem to remember my wife being there — she wasn't my wife at that time — but a girl I'd started to go with was the camera girl at Birdland. And at that time I was at the Hickory House with Marian McPartland. And I used to go over there. And I remember us standing together listening to Joe Williams. And I think it was the first time I'd heard him. So I think that was probably the second or third time that the band came through. But I was thrilled with that band. I couldn't believe how good they sounded. And we would just sit there every night between sets and listen to them play, you know it was an ideal learning situation.

MR: What was it about that rhythm section that made it so identifiable?

BC: Well by that time of course I had memorized the Basie records. That was one of the things Buzzy did for me when I first met him in Seattle, was he said, "You don't know about the Count Basie band?" He got out all the, especially the old Deccas with Lester on them, and played me all of those things. And he listened to me play drums a couple of times when I was at jam sessions and things, and he liked the way I played well enough to send me in to sub for him, because he knew I didn't play as well as he did and I couldn't take his job away. But he sat me down one day in his room and he said, "What do you think about when you play the drums?" You know, I said, "Well I think about putting the beats in the right place and not speeding up and not slowing down, and that seemed to be the big issue with the rest of the band." He said, "Well yeah but what about swinging?" I said, "I don't really know what that means, I've heard that term but I don't really know what that means." And I couldn't have asked a better guy, because he was the one person I've ever met in my life that was able to describe it. He put on some really swinging records. I remember there was a V disc he had of Duke playing "Jumpin' Punkins" that was a much better take than the one they released on Victor, and three or four others, like "Poundcake" from the Basie band and "Avenue C" and some of those things. And he got up and danced out the swing and showed me, "Now look what the drummer's doing here." You know, say "Look what happens, look what the band did there, look what this arrangement causes to happen, look what the soloist did there." All

in rhythmic terms, and I just, it was like the scales fell from my eyes, I saw immediately what he was talking about. And from then on I had some kind of an ideal, rhythmically, to shoot for. So that was when I got to hear this version of the Basie band, I thought Gus Johnson was ideal, because he was doing the same kind of thing in the rhythm section. Gus had an interesting style of playing his cymbal beat was kind of up on the top of the beat. And it wasn't a loose, you know, the way the time is divided in swing, each of the four beats has a kind of a triplet division rather than rock divides it by two, jazz divides it by three. And that quality that Jo Jones had kind of established of [scats] it's like a loose pattern that he always played that you heard behind everything, Gus' was a little more [scats]. It was, the triplet was pushed up a little farther. But when he would play a figure around the drums, it would be laid back. It would almost be behind the beat. And the combination of those two, it kept the time up where it belonged, so he was right on Freddie Green's time, and at the same time he encouraged that loose phrasing that the band had. I thought he was the ideal drummer. I was very disappointed with they replaced him with Sonny Payne, although I could see why they did it. Sonny was a showman. But I didn't think that, to sacrifice the heartbeat of that band to a showman was the right move. Commercially I guess it was a very good move. Basie took his manager's advice about it. But I tell you, I liked Gus so much that years later when neither Mel Lewis or Dave Bailey were available for a Gerry Mulligan quartet job, and Gerry asked us for recommendations, I said I know Gus Johnson's not doing anything right now, and I talked them into hiring him and he stayed with us for about year. I thought he was a wonderful addition to that group.

MR: And Joe's hit, he had that hit "Every Day I Have the Blues." It was about that time, wasn't it?

BC: Well when he came, the first time he came through with the band, he had I think maybe four really strong arrangements. He had "Every Day," he had "In the Evening When the Sun Goes Down," he had "The Comeback," and I can't remember what else. I know Frank Foster had done something for him and Ernie Wilkins had done something for him. And they were just ideal arrangements. Ernie had that understanding of the old riff patterns that grew up in the old Basie band, and he was able to write new stuff that called up that rhythmic quality and that togetherness quality. Guys would play his arrangements and it was like they'd always known them. I remember that album that he did for Joe Turner has those kind of arrangements. "The Boss of the Blues" album. Wonderful. It's just out of the blues tradition, a tremendous organization of forms that everybody has known forever.

MR: It's a real skill to be able to write something that comes from really, if it was just played from the top of your head, to try to put that on paper.

BC: Yeah, oh, yeah. So Joe was very well supported by those arrangements. They really, and he knew what to do with them. He had an instrument and an ability to sing and actually he was kind of bugged about getting locked into the image of being a blues singer, because he wanted to be a ballad singer. And he knew he could do it, and he felt that he had come into the world of being a singer kind of on the tail end of the time when those kind of singers were easily promoted and sold to the general public. So you know he was glad to have the gig with a major band but he really hated the fact that all he got to do was these three or four blues charts that Basie had for him. And Basie could see what an impact he was having on the audience, you know. I mean and it was only about his voice. Because at that time he had no stage presence at all. You know he had a bad haircut, it was shaved way up to the top of his head, and he had a jacket that was too short for him, and he would just come out and hold his hands like this and close his eyes and sing. And made very little eye contact with the audience you know. But I mean it was dynamite. Everybody would just fall all over themselves and so became a star immediately. It wasn't too long that he loosened up and started to play to audiences, got a better tailor, got a better barber. And by the time that band had been coming through there for a couple, three years, Joe had really turned into a — well it's very much like what happened to Tony Bennett. The first time I heard Tony I was over at Jack Segal's house, the songwriter that wrote "When Sunny Gets Blue" and "Scarlet Ribbons" and some of those songs. And Jack was busy in the Brill Building world, he knew people and he knew songwriters, and he was always good for a dinner and a loan of $5 if I would go over there scuffling. And he was a nice guy, and we always had parties at his house. And we would do things like sit around reading Clifford Odets' plays or singing. It was very entertainment oriented happening over at his house. And one time I was over there and this guy brings Tony Bennett by and says, "I want you to hear this young singer I got and see what you think." And he was kind of a straight, not jazz oriented singer at all, not even pop jazz oriented. He was singing like an Eddie Fisher type of singer. And he sang a little flat on his high notes, and he was singing loud, full, like out of the Milanese pop song style, almost operatic you know, except he didn't make those operatic noises that opera singers do. And the next thing we knew, somebody had gotten him, well it was mob connections, they had gotten him a record contract with Columbia, and they gave Mitch Miller the job of promoting him. And Mitch realized that he had an interesting anguished sound in his upper register, so he deliberately put him a key or two higher than he really was comfortable singing, and then he'd have him do eight or ten takes until he really sounded like he was dying and there were songs about mama and love and all of that, and he gave it an emotional quality that Mitch knew was marketable. So he got popular enough, and you know Tony was a darling guy, just a really, everybody liked

him he was such a nice man, and kind of innocent. And I just heard this on the grapevine, I never discussed it with Tony, but I heard that he bought his contract away from these guys that originally backed him, and they charged him a nice taste, but they were willing to let him go because he was a nice guy. And then I think it was either hearing the Basie band or getting a chance to work opposite the Basie band, he realized that that was the kind of the background he would like to hear behind him. He liked it. And also the first time that he got out with a supper club audience, he fell in love with audiences. It turns out that he had this ability to really relate to people in a very personal way as a performer. And it just changed him completely. He became an entirely different singer than he ever had been before. So jazz had a very good influence on him I think. Basie had a good influence.

MR: Yeah. Well he made some marvelous records with Basie too.

BC: Yeah.

MR: Well let me ask you about this book. What prompted you to get into this idea of trying to — this is a mammoth project.

BC: Well I'll tell you, I've always loved musicians' stories, and it's been one of the nicest things about hanging out with musicians is that they remember even adversity in humorous terms after the original pain is over. And I used to love to sit around and listen to Roy Eldridge tell stories, and Hot Lips Page and people like that. It would just knock me out that there was such a slice of life there, and usually it was a funny story about somebody else. You know you could rag on somebody to tell about their foibles or weaknesses or some time that they were taken for a fool or whatever. So I can't imagine how many times I've heard, during one of these story sessions, somebody say, boy somebody should write these down, these are great. So about the time I got involved in Local 802, the New York Musician's Union, the new president, we all got swept in on like a clean slate, I think we got tired of what the old administration was doing. And John Glasel said, "By golly, if I can't get somebody else to run for president I'll do it myself" and, "how many of you guys are willing to be on the board?" So only the top four officers had to give up their musical careers in order to be union officials, so I didn't mind being on the board, and I was willing to run for office. And we were surprised that we all got elected, and none of the old administration was left in at all. So there was a monthly newspaper that the union published, and John was looking for material for it, and he said, "How'd you like to write a column?" And I said, "Yes, I would, and I know exactly the column I'd like to write, I'd like to start of putting some of these musicians stories in there." So the first six months I guess, I just wrote stuff that I remembered people having told me or things that had happened to me personally. And it got so popular among the musicians they started sending me stuff, and I've never run out of

material. I've been doing it for something like twelve years now. And I still every time I put together my month's column I look and I see that I still have enough for another column in my computer, and by the time I get around to the next month I've gathered enough other things that I've still, I've never had to reach back or hurry and interview somebody. It's just been a natural thing. So well I really got started writing again in the 80s there someplace. I knew Gene Lees who had been the editor of *Down Beat* for quite a while, in one of his past lives, and during that period I'd gotten to know him because he was hanging around Jim & Andy's in New York a lot and he got to know a lot of the musicians. And he was also a songwriter. And he had ended up out in California and was publishing a little, like a monthly newsletter called "Jazz Letter." And I can't remember, because he'd been doing this for a couple of years before I'd heard about it, somebody sent me a gift subscription I guess it was. And I was so pleased with it that, you know the stuff that he wrote and stuff that other people wrote that he would put in there, so I wrote him a letter and said do you have any back issues available, and he sends me a gift of all of the back issues for the last two years, and also a letter that said I remember when you came back from the Russian tour with Benny Goodman in the 60s there, that you told a lot of funny stories about what a catastrophe that trip was, and what would you think about doing an article for "Jazz Letter" you know. He says I can't pay you anything but you can tell it the way it was and I promise not to edit it. So I got to thinking about it and thought it would be fun to do, and I figured when I started it would just be recollections, I could do it in maybe 2,000 words and that would be that. But as I started getting back into it, then I started calling up guys that were on the band that were still around — Phil Woods and Jerry Dodgion and different guys. Joe Wilder — I was working with Joe Wilder at that time, and Wayne Andre and Jimmy Maxwell. And so we reconstructed the thing and I got more and more material, and it ended up being quite a long essay. Gene published it in about four different issues of "Jazz Letter." And that got me back into the business of not just writing but of trying to write well, which for me means writing it down and then going back and editing it about four hundred times until you get it said, you know get the sentences to really say what you want them to say and get the ambiguities out of there and try to get the organization of the thing so that it goes somewhere. And when it was all over, I was still doing the column and stuff life that, and I guess Sheldon Meyer, one of the heads of the New York Oxford University Press Division is a jazz fan, and had been instrumental in getting a number of autobiographies published there. And Gene was one of his writers, and Dick Sudhalter was one of his writers. So when he asked these, I guess Oxford had done some other anecdote collections, one from the theater, one from literature, one from the opera, one from the military or something like that. So Sheldon was all hot on the idea of doing a jazz

anecdotes collection. And he asked his writers, who would you recommend to edit this. And they both pointed at me. So he called me up and I sent him a bunch of my back columns, and he said, "Oh yes, you're exactly the person we want — let's make a deal." So we did, and then it took me about two years to—

MR: Yeah, I can imagine.

BC: You know I started with my own stuff. Then I went to the Lincoln Center Library and read every jazz book they had, and then I started seeing references to books that they didn't have. So I called up Dan Morgenstern over at the Institute of Jazz Studies and he said, oh yeah, we've got all that stuff here. So about once or twice a week for the next year I would go over there and read all the books that they had and I discovered the oral history collection there. I went through that and I extracted every story that I could find. Fortunately my son had gotten me interested in having a computer in the house. I had an old Radio Shack Model I, it was like a Model A Ford. So I upgraded it to disc drives and upper and lower case and stuff like that, and that was the machine that I wrote this book on. So I was able to do all of that editing and rearranging and keeping track of sources and all that stuff. I think it would have driven us out of the house if I had to do that on paper with file cards and stuff. And so I got it written, and Sheldon was very helpful in some suggestions about organizing the book and once they accepted the final draft of it, then it took me another six months to get permission to use all of the sources.

MR: Yeah, quite an extensive list of acknowledgments.

BC: So I wrote all of these letters and sometimes it would turn out that the publisher of an out-of-print book, the rights had transferred to three or four other locations. In one case, I never did find who owned it. I couldn't. It was just one of those things. I figured well it's out there, and if somebody finally does write and claim a permissions payment I'll be glad to give it to them but I just can't find this one. But I did, I tied all the rest of them down and got permissions letters and all of that.

MR: So when does Volume II come out?

BC: Well, when I was putting together this volume, I decided that the stories of my own experience had a little different color to them. So I saved them all out, just on a hunch. And when this was successful I said to Sheldon, "You know I've got another book" I said, "this one's more of an autobiography, but it's stories." And he said, "okay." So I wrote *From Birdland to Broadway,* that was my second one. I don't really want to do Son Of Jazz Anecdotes. I told the best ones in that book and there's still a lot of stories around, and a lot of the ones that I do from my column are not particularly from the jazz world, they are musician stories from other venues. And if I get some kind of a focus for that I might try making another book out of that. But I am fooling around with some of the stories I couldn't tell for personal reasons, people who are still alive — but the stories

are so good that I'm using them as plots for short stories and I'm trying to teach myself to write fiction. It's hard. It's, I don't know if I'll ever get good enough at it to bring it out in public, but it's something that I play with at home.

MR: Well you seem to keep pretty busy with that and the work in the Local and you still go around this area playing bass.

BC: Oh, yeah, I play at least two nights a week and sometimes more. I play a lot with Carmen Leggio over in Westchester, with Joe Shepley, he's got a steady Wednesday down in Yonkers, I play with him, and all the guys come by to play with us so I get to play with George Young and Lou Delgado, guys like that, and some young players that Joe knows that are coming along real good. Well I took up the tuba while I was doing Broadway shows. I went back to a brass instrument after 25 years of not having touched one. And I found out I like the tuba a lot. So it relates very closely to a baritone horn, it's just a larger member of the same family. So in order to keep my lip together on that I go rehearse with the Rockland County Concert Band and sometimes the Saddle River Concert Band down in New Jersey, and I do concerts with them when I can. And during the summer there's a lot of Dixieland work on tuba, where my knowledge of those old tunes comes in handy. And once in a while, for economic reasons, they send out a group like to a store opening or an auto opening, where they want a kind of a Dixieland group but they don't want to pay a full Dixieland band. So they'll send out maybe drums, banjo, tuba and clarinet. Or one time I did it with just banjo and tuba. And I love those jobs because I get to fill in all of the missing parts. I can play the trombone parts, and I get to take a lot more solos that way you know, and it's really interesting to me.

MR: Wow. You must be tired by the time it's done.

BC: No it's very refreshing. Once in a while if I haven't been playing much during that week and then do a four hour job that's a lot of playing, my lip will get tired, but it wakes me right up, makes me feel like playing music. It's an interesting challenge.

MR: Great. Well this has really been fascinating.

BC: Did you know that my books have been translated into Japanese?

MR: No kidding? And well that makes sense because in Japan, they love jazz over there, right?

BC: Well this guy called me up. He's a Japanese writer himself. He's done short stories in Japanese and he was studying up in Boston somewhere and is fluent in English. But he doesn't do his own English translations of his own stories, someone else has done those. But he told me that his publisher had made a deal with Oxford for him to do a translation into Japanese and he wanted to do an interview. So on the strength of that I'm finally getting to do a record in my own name, from a Japanese record company that wants to tie it in with the book being released over there. So I'm going to use the group that I play

with here in Westchester — Carmen Leggio and Joe Cohn, Al Cohn's son, a good guitar player, and a drummer named Dave Jones that we've been playing with, a very good drummer.

MR: Well that's great.

BC: So we're doing that next month.

MR: Well on behalf of the college I'd like to thank you for taking the time out to tell your story.

BC: Well it's a pleasure. Everybody likes to talk about themself.

MR: I was going to say, "Pick one favorite story out of that." But you just—

BC: It's like saying pick a favorite tune. You know I just, I really can't do that. I always loved the one I'm involved in at the moment. I'll give you a new story that's not in there. Gene Bertoncini was chatting up a girl on the street while he was waiting for Bobby Shanken to come down, the drummer. And Gene is a very handsome guy and beautifully dressed usually, and very tidy. And when he told her that he was a guitar player, she didn't believe him. She said, "You don't look like a guitar player." She's thinking of rock guitar players. So Bobby comes down, and he says, "Bobby, would you explain to this young lady how I make my living?" And Bobby says, "Well, he's one of the best jazz players in the world, and I have no idea how he makes his living."

MR: Good one. All right. Well thanks for your time.

BC: Sure.

MR: It's been a real pleasure.